

compounding ahead. If anything, meaningful price decreases created genuine buying opportunities to accumulate more investments (not that I was smart enough to take advantage of them).

But at the time, that was not how it felt. In a new job where market levels affected salary, bonuses, economic stability, and even financial survival, it did not feel good. In fact, *it felt horrible*. People all around me freaked out, stress levels went through the roof.

These early bear markets mattered very little to me financially, but that was not how it felt at the time.

Where things begin to get interesting is in the latter years of my career. By then, we began to have substantial assets in our savings/retirement accounts. Bear markets would meaningfully impact those finances. The GFC and the pandemic were global phenomena; the 2022 market was the worst since 1981 for a 60/40 portfolio. Not only is my portfolio substantially larger, but my entire business—about \$5 billion dollars of client assets managed at Ritholtz Wealth Management—is tied to markets. As is my 401k, my salary, my quarterly profit distributions, and my annual bonus. And, the value of the firm!

Downturns literally cost millions and should hurt a lot... but they don't, and in fact, they have the exact opposite effect. *These recent bear markets mattered a great deal to me economically but did not feel that way*. This was curious. The more you think about it, the more it makes sense.

Reframe the idea of bear markets by putting them into a broader context of life experiences. You get older, you've lived through these things before; you know *everything* is cyclical. “This too shall pass” is attributed to King Solomon, an adage to remind the sovereign to be humble in the face of good times and optimistic in periods of despair.

Markets are the same: They go up, they go down, and all of it is out of your control. We are reminded by Stoic philosophers like Marcus Aurelius that